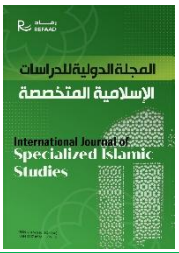
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Artificial Intelligence, Religious Authority, and Digital Governance: A Maqasid Framework for Governing Religious Knowledge and Protecting Intellectual Security

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الذكاء الاصطناعي والسلطة الدينية والحوكمة الرقمية: إطار مقاصدي لضبط المعرفة الدينية وحماية الأمن الفكري

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Abstract:

Objectives: This study analyzes how generative artificial intelligence and algorithmic recommendation systems are becoming epistemic structures that shape the production, consumption, and justification of religious knowledge, especially in Western European Muslim minority contexts where translation needs, rapid access, fragmented local authority, and platform attention economies intersect.

Methods: Using an integrative conceptual synthesis that brings together AI ethics, digital religion scholarship, and Islamic ethics, the article proposes a practical maqasid-based framework centered on protecting religion (hifz al-din) and protecting intellect (hifz al-'aql) as criteria for evaluating risks and designing safeguards. The framework is translated into implementable governance tools: source-provenance and verification protocols for Qur'anic, hadith, and juristic citations; explicit communication of uncertainty; contestability and review mechanisms; qualified human-in-the-loop oversight for fatwa-like guidance and religious counseling; and community-facing digital and AI literacy programs.

Conclusions: The study concludes that AI can support access and learning in religious knowledge domains when governed by clear ethical and institutional safeguards, and it proposes an empirical research agenda for systematically auditing model outputs in common religious queries.

Keywords: *generative AI; algorithmic authority; digital religion; intellectual security; attribution integrity; AI ethics; maqasid al-shari'ah; Muslim minorities.*

الملخص:

الأهداف: تهدف هذه الدراسة إلى تحليل تحوّل الذكاء الاصطناعي التوليدي وأنظمة التوصية الخوارزمية إلى بنى معرفية تؤثر في إنتاج المعرفة الدينية واستهلاكها وتبريرها، وبخاصة في سياقات الأقليات المسلمة في أوروبا الغربية حيث تتقاطع الحاجة إلى الترجمة والوصول السريع مع تفتت المرجعية المحلية واقتصاد الانتباه على المنصات.

المنهجية: تعتمد الدراسة مقاربة تركيبية مفهومية عابرة للتخصصات تجمع بين أدبيات أخلاقيات الذكاء الاصطناعي، ودراسات الدين الرقمي، والأخلاقيات الإسلامية، وتقترح إطارًا مقاصديًا عمليًا يركز على حفظ الدين وحفظ العقل بوصفهما معيارين لتقويم المخاطر ووضع الضمانات. ويُترجم هذا الإطار إلى مجموعة أدوات حوكمة قابلة للتطبيق، تشمل بروتوكولات إثبات المصدر والتحقق من الاقتباسات القرآنية والحديثية والفقهية، والإفصاح عن عدم اليقين، وقابلية الطعن والمراجعة، وإبقاء الخبرة البشرية المؤهلة في الحلقة عند الفتوى أو الإرشاد، إلى جانب برامج محو الأمية الرقمية والذكاء الاصطناعي للمجتمع.

الخلاصة: تخلص الدراسة إلى أن دمج الذكاء الاصطناعي في مجالات المعرفة الدينية يمكن أن يدعم التعلم والوصول إذا حُكم بضوابط أخلاقية ومؤسسية واضحة، كما تطرح أجندة بحثية للتحقق التجريبي من الإطار عبر تدقيقات منهجية لمخرجات النماذج في أسئلة دينية شائعة.

الكلمات المفتاحية: *الذكاء الاصطناعي التوليدي؛ السلطة الخوارزمية؛ الدين الرقمي؛ الأمن الفكري؛ سلامة الإسناد؛ أخلاقيات الذكاء الاصطناعي؛ مقاصد الشريعة؛ الأقليات المسلمة.*

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1 Introduction

The rapid diffusion of generative artificial intelligence (AI) and algorithmic recommendation systems is transforming how knowledge is produced, discovered, summarized, and trusted across society. In practice, these systems do not merely retrieve information: they repackage it, rank it, translate it, and present answers in persuasive natural language. Scholars have therefore begun to describe generative AI as a technology that can reconfigure epistemic authority in learning environments, with users sometimes attributing credibility to fluent algorithmic outputs rather than to human experts or peer-reviewed sources (Jose et al., 2025). In high-stakes domains, these dynamics intersect with long-standing concerns about opacity, accountability, and the uneven social distribution of error and harm (Barocas & Selbst, 2016; Benjamin, 2019; Noble, 2018).

Religious knowledge domains are distinctive because they are simultaneously informational, normative, and identity-forming. Users often approach religious questions under moral urgency, emotional vulnerability, or limited access to qualified counsel. Digital religion scholarship has shown that online religious environments can widen access to learning while also complicating religious authority, especially when platforms and interface design shape what counts as visible and credible religious knowledge (Campbell, 2013; Hjarvard, 2011). In Muslim contexts, the expansion of "cyber-Islamic environments" has already altered patterns of religious authority, guidance-seeking, and contestation, both in Muslim-majority societies and in minority settings (Bunt, 2003, 2018; Eickelman & Anderson, 2003; Larsson, 2011). Generative AI extends these developments by providing conversational answers, translations, summaries, and even sermon-like drafts, thereby functioning as an epistemic intermediary rather than a neutral tool.

The epistemic risks of AI-mediated religious guidance are well documented in adjacent literatures. Large language models can produce plausible but false statements and may reproduce biases embedded in training data (Bender et al., 2021). Information disorders on social platforms are shaped by attention economies and algorithmic ranking, where false content can diffuse rapidly and corrections often fail to fully dislodge misperceptions (Lazer et al., 2018; Lewandowsky et al., 2012; Nyhan & Reifler, 2010; Vosoughi et al., 2018). Automation bias further amplifies overreliance on algorithmic outputs, producing complacency and reduced vigilance in verification (Parasuraman & Manzey, 2010; Parasuraman & Riley, 1997). In the religious domain, these failure modes translate into risks of fabricated or misattributed Qur'anic and hadith citations, decontextualized moral-legal claims, and untraceable synthesis across competing traditions.

This article argues that these problems should be treated not simply as accuracy issues but as challenges of epistemic security and information integrity: the robustness of knowledge practices against distortion, unjustified authority, and manipulation. Addressing epistemic security requires governance measures that are both technical (provenance, documentation, interpretability) and social (institutional protocols, user literacy, contestability). In AI ethics, there is an expanding consensus that high-level principles must be operationalized into implementable practices and documentation regimes (Floridi & Cowls, 2018; Jobin et al., 2019; Mitchell et al., 2019; Morley et al., 2023). Explainability methods can improve transparency in some settings, but they also raise questions about what kinds of explanations are meaningful to users and adequate for accountability (Guidotti et al., 2018; Ribeiro et al., 2016). For high-stakes decisions, scholars have argued that interpretable models may be preferable to post-hoc explanations of opaque systems (Rudin, 2019).

From within Islamic ethical thought, epistemic security is not peripheral. The Qur'an cautions against following claims without knowledge (Qur'an 17:36) and calls for verification in the transmission of information (Qur'an 49:6). Islamic legal-ethical traditions also emphasize qualified interpretation, reliable transmission, and disciplined reasoning as safeguards against distortion. Maqasid al-shari'ah (the higher objectives of Islamic law) provides a tradition-grounded yet adaptable framework for evaluating socio-technical change, particularly through the objectives of protecting religion (hifz al-din) and protecting intellect (hifz al-'aql) (Auda, 2008; Ibn Ashur, 2006; Opwis, 2005). Recent scholarship has begun to translate Islamic ethical resources into AI ethics debates, arguing for pluralist benchmarking and trusteeship-based approaches (Ali et al., 2025; Elmahjub, 2023).

Accordingly, this paper develops a maqasid-informed governance framework for AI-mediated religious guidance. It contributes (1) an interdisciplinary risk taxonomy for epistemic harms in religious AI use; (2) an operational translation of hifz al-din and hifz al-'aql into implementable safeguards at the levels of system design, institutional governance, and user practice; and (3) an illustrative application to Sunni Muslim minority contexts in Western Europe, where language barriers, fragmented authority structures, and platform dynamics may magnify both the benefits and risks of AI-mediated guidance (Bowen, 2010; Cesari, 2013; Roy, 2004).

This study therefore positions generative AI in religious contexts not merely as a technological or pedagogical issue, but as a matter of digital governance, understood as the normative, institutional, and socio-

technical arrangements that regulate authority, accountability, and epistemic integrity in digitally mediated religious knowledge.

2 Background and Related Work

2.1 Generative AI, documentation, and epistemic risk

Generative AI systems raise governance concerns because their outputs are shaped by statistical pattern learning rather than by truth-tracking procedures. The critique of "stochastic parrots" highlights how scale can amplify environmental and social costs while producing systems that may generate fluent but unreliable text, including in contexts where users may incorrectly infer authority or expertise (Bender et al., 2021). The challenge is intensified in high-stakes or identity-sensitive domains, where incorrect outputs can cause more than inconvenience; they can reshape beliefs, decisions, and community relations.

In response, AI governance research has emphasized documentation, transparency, and accountability mechanisms. Model documentation proposals such as model cards were developed to communicate intended use, performance characteristics, limitations, and ethical considerations, thereby reducing misapplication and enabling more informed oversight (Mitchell et al., 2019). Explainability has similarly grown as a field of practice and evaluation: local explanation techniques such as Local Interpretable Model-agnostic Explanations (LIME) attempt to make model behavior auditable by approximating decision boundaries around specific inputs (Ribeiro et al., 2016), while surveys have catalogued a broad set of approaches and unresolved questions about interpretability and explanation quality (Guidotti et al., 2018). A related debate argues that in genuinely high-stakes settings, the appropriate governance move may be to use interpretable models rather than rely on post-hoc explanations for opaque systems (Rudin, 2019).

These governance themes align with the wider landscape of AI ethics guidelines and principle frameworks. Comparative reviews show convergence around themes such as transparency, fairness, accountability, and human oversight, but also warn that principles alone are insufficient without operational pathways and institutional incentives (Floridi & Cowls, 2018; Jobin et al., 2019). Work on operationalizing AI ethics further identifies barriers such as unclear responsibility, limited technical resources, and organizational constraints, underscoring the need for practical toolkits and governance routines rather than abstract commitments (Morley et al., 2023).

2.2 Misinformation, ranking, and automation bias

The epistemic risks of AI-mediated religious guidance should also be situated within research on misinformation and platform dynamics. Across multiple studies, false content has been shown to spread rapidly online, often outperforming true content in diffusion speed and reach (Vosoughi et al., 2018). The prevalence of misinformation dissemination is unevenly distributed, with a small subset of users accounting for a disproportionate share of sharing behavior in some contexts (Guess et al., 2019). The persistence of misinformation is reinforced by cognitive and social mechanisms: corrections can fail to dislodge misperceptions (Nyhan & Reifler, 2010), and misinformation can continue to influence reasoning even after it is corrected (Lewandowsky et al., 2012).

A significant body of work emphasizes that susceptibility to misinformation is often associated with limited analytical reasoning rather than simple ideological motivation, suggesting that interventions may need to strengthen reasoning practices and epistemic vigilance (Pennycook & Rand, 2019). Reviews in cognitive science further synthesize the mechanisms through which misinformation spreads and how attention, repetition, and social endorsement shape belief formation (Pennycook & Rand, 2021). These insights support the argument that AI literacy and verification habits are not optional add-ons but essential safeguards in knowledge domains where users may be especially reliant on plausible, authoritative-sounding outputs.

Platform studies show that ranking and recommendation systems shape what users encounter and trust. Empirical work on social media indicates that exposure to ideologically diverse information is filtered through both personal networks and platform ranking, with measurable effects on what content users see and engage with (Bakshy et al., 2015). Research on online news consumption similarly documents the role of algorithmic curation and user choice in creating filter bubble dynamics (Flaxman et al., 2016). Since religious learning online often occurs through search rankings and recommendation feeds, these mechanisms can elevate unqualified voices and polarizing content, complicating authority and verification.

A further challenge is automation bias: users may over-trust algorithmic outputs, especially when systems appear confident or when the user is time-constrained. Classic work on automation misuse and disuse

highlights that human interaction with automated systems can produce systematic failure modes, including overreliance and complacency (Parasuraman & Riley, 1997). Later studies describe how attention and workload influence complacency and bias in human use of automation (Parasuraman & Manzey, 2010). These effects are relevant to generative AI interfaces because conversational systems can produce persuasive outputs that suppress the user's impulse to verify sources.

2.3 Digital religion and online Islamic authority

The mediatization of religion refers to how media technologies become embedded in religious practice and reshape religious institutions, authority, and meaning-making (Hjarvard, 2011). Digital religion scholarship has developed analytic tools for examining how religious actors negotiate authority, community, and authenticity in online spaces, often through hybrid practices that blend offline and online forms of engagement (Campbell, 2013). In many traditions, platform architectures and moderation regimes shape what religious content is visible, acceptable, or monetizable, raising governance questions about the hidden decisions that structure public discourse (Gillespie, 2018).

In Muslim contexts, earlier scholarship on new media emphasized the emergence of new publics and new modes of authority contestation, where religious knowledge could circulate outside traditional institutional pathways (Eickelman & Anderson, 2003). Studies of cyber-Islamic environments document how online fatwa portals, activist media, and transnational networks reshape guidance-seeking and religious authority, including the rise of e-jihad discourse and the proliferation of online mujtahid-like figures (Bunt, 2003). Later work further develops how hashtags, social networks, and platform affordances transform religious authority, making it more performative, networked, and attention-dependent (Bunt, 2018).

Research on Muslims and new media highlights both empowerment and risk. Digital environments can expand access to learning, facilitate multilingual engagement, and connect diasporic communities to transnational scholarship; yet they can also expose users to polemical content, misinformation, and authority fragmentation (Larsson, 2011). A recent scoping review synthesizes the growing literature on Muslims and social media, emphasizing how the field has expanded to address platforms, identity negotiation, and the interplay between religion and digital participation (Larsson & Willander, 2024). These literatures create a foundation for analyzing generative AI as an extension of platform-mediated religion, but with novel risks arising from generated text, synthetic citation, and conversational authority.

2.4 Muslim diasporas in Western Europe: authority, pluralism, and identity

Muslim minority contexts in Western Europe provide a salient setting for examining AI-mediated religious guidance because they combine pluralism, securitization pressures, and fragmented religious infrastructures. Sociological and political analyses describe how European publics have often framed Islam through fear narratives, integration debates, and security discourses that shape the everyday conditions of Muslim life (Cesari, 2013). Ethnographic and legal scholarship on Muslims in France illustrates how secularist regimes and national integration models shape religious practice, institutional authority, and public visibility (Bowen, 2010). At the transnational level, Muslim identities and discourses are shaped by global flows of religious authority and politics. Studies of transnational Muslim politics describe how diasporic communities negotiate belonging and authority through networks that reimagine the umma beyond nation-state boundaries (Mandaville, 2001). Analyses of globalized Islam highlight the rise of decultured or deterritorialized religiosity, often mediated by global communications and contestations over authenticity (Roy, 2004). In digital spaces, these dynamics can intensify: users can access multiple, conflicting authorities, while platforms reward engagement rather than scholarly discipline.

2.5 Algorithmic bias, discrimination, and social power

Epistemic security concerns also intersect with the politics of classification and representation. Work on disparate impact in data-driven systems shows that algorithmic decision-making can reproduce and legitimate discrimination, even when explicit intent to discriminate is absent (Barocas & Selbst, 2016). Empirical audits of commercial computer vision systems demonstrate measurable disparities in accuracy across gender and skin tone, illustrating how technical performance can be unevenly distributed across groups (Buolamwini & Gebru, 2018). Critical scholarship further argues that search engines and data infrastructures can amplify racialized and stigmatizing representations, shaping what users come to "know" about marginalized communities (Benjamin, 2019; Noble, 2018).

In the context of Islam and Muslims, bias can manifest as stereotyping, hostile framings, or the privileging of sensational content that reinforces securitized narratives. When generative AI systems are trained on heterogeneous web corpora, they may reproduce Islamophobic or reductionist representations, and when they are embedded in platform ecosystems governed by moderation and ranking policies, those representations can be amplified or normalized (Gillespie, 2018). These concerns motivate the need for bias-aware auditing and culturally sensitive governance in religious knowledge applications.

3 Methodological Approach

This article adopts a conceptual and integrative synthesis methodology situated at the intersection of AI ethics, misinformation research, digital religion studies, and Islamic legal-ethical thought. The goal is not to report new human-subject fieldwork, but to consolidate a cross-disciplinary risk landscape and translate a tradition-based normative framework into implementable safeguards. The analysis proceeds in three stages.

First, it synthesizes scholarship on generative AI risks, platform dynamics, misinformation diffusion, and automation bias to identify recurrent epistemic failure modes that are likely to appear in religious query contexts (Bender et al., 2021; Lazer et al., 2018; Parasuraman & Riley, 1997; Vosoughi et al., 2018). Second, it develops an Islamic normative lens by operationalizing maqasid al-shari'ah, with particular focus on protecting religion (hifz al-din) and protecting intellect (hifz al-'aql), drawing on legal theory and maqasid scholarship (Auda, 2008; Hallaq, 1997; Ibn Ashur, 2006; Opwis, 2005). Third, it translates the resulting criteria into a practical safeguard toolkit organized at three levels: system-level safeguards, institutional governance protocols, and user/community practices.

References to Muslim minority settings in Western Europe (Belgium, the Netherlands, France, and England) are used illustratively to show how contextual factors such as multilingualism, fragmented religious authority, and platform attention economies may shape risk exposure and mitigation priorities (Bowen, 2010; Cesari, 2013). The article concludes with a validation agenda that can test and refine the framework through empirical work, including systematic prompt audits, community-based studies, and institutional case analyses.

4 Islamic Ethical Foundations: Knowledge, Authority, and Maqasid

4.1 Verification, authority, and disciplined reasoning

Islamic knowledge traditions emphasize disciplined reasoning, reliable transmission, and qualified interpretation. In Sunni usul al-fiqh, evidence is evaluated through developed methods of textual interpretation, linguistic analysis, and reasoning about purposes and causes. Historical work on Sunni legal theory shows how jurists constructed methodological tools to regulate inference and the use of reports, thereby safeguarding religious knowledge from arbitrariness and distortion (Hallaq, 1997). These tools are not reducible to a mechanical procedure; they are embedded in scholarly training, ethical accountability, and communal forms of verification.

From an interdisciplinary perspective, the significance of these traditions is that they treat knowledge as a practice governed by norms of attribution and accountability. The Qur'anic calls to avoid ungrounded claims and to verify transmitted information can be interpreted as a normative basis for epistemic security: claims should be traceable, and those who transmit or act on information bear responsibility for verification (Qur'an 17:36; 49:6). When AI systems generate religious answers without reliable provenance or without communicating uncertainty, they risk bypassing these safeguards and encouraging epistemic complacency.

4.2 Maqasid al-shari'ah as a governance lens

Maqasid al-shari'ah (the higher objectives of Islamic law) provides a tradition-based framework for evaluating socio-technical change by assessing whether practices secure benefit (maslahah) and prevent harm (mafsadah). The historical development of maslahah reasoning and legal change shows that Islamic discourse has long debated how purpose-based reasoning can guide adaptation while remaining anchored to authoritative sources (Opwis, 2005). Modern system-oriented interpretations of maqasid emphasize complexity, interdependence, and the need to evaluate outcomes rather than isolated rules (Auda, 2008).

In this article, maqasid is not used to derive binding legal rulings about specific AI technologies. Rather, it is operationalized as an ethical-governance vocabulary that can be translated into implementable safeguards. Two objectives are foregrounded because of their direct relevance to epistemic security: protecting religion (hifz al-din) and protecting intellect (hifz al-'aql). Ibn Ashur's reformulation of maqasid highlights the moral and

civilizational significance of safeguarding religious meaning and rational capacities in changing conditions (Ibn Ashur, 2006). In AI-mediated religious guidance, these objectives can be translated into criteria such as attribution integrity, interpretive non-usurpation, uncertainty communication, and contestability.

4.3 Emerging Islamic approaches to AI ethics

Recent scholarship has begun to articulate Islamic contributions to AI ethics in a manner that is legible to pluralistic policy and governance contexts. Elmahjub (2023) proposes an Islamic ethical framework for pluralist benchmarking of AI design and use, arguing that Islamic moral concepts can inform regulatory and evaluative standards beyond Western-centric paradigms. Ali et al. (2025) further evaluate existing AI ethics approaches through the lens of trusteeship ethics, emphasizing responsibility, accountability, and the moral status of human agency in relation to technology. These works support the broader claim that Islamic normative resources can contribute to interdisciplinary AI governance, provided they are translated into operational safeguards and verification practices rather than remaining at the level of abstract moral exhortation.

5 Epistemic Failure Modes in AI-Mediated Religious Guidance

To design safeguards, it is necessary to specify the recurrent failure modes that threaten epistemic security in AI-mediated religious guidance. The taxonomy below synthesizes risk patterns identified in AI ethics, misinformation research, and digital religion studies, translating them into a vocabulary suitable for governance and institutional practice (Bender et al., 2021; Gillespie, 2018; Lazer et al., 2018).

First, fabrication and false attribution occur when generative systems produce invented Qur'anic verses, fabricated hadith, or misattributed juristic claims. Because large language models are optimized for linguistic plausibility rather than truth, they can generate citation-like content that appears authoritative while lacking verification (Bender et al., 2021). In religious settings, where attribution and chain-of-transmission logic are central, fabrication directly threatens hifz al-din and hifz al-'aql.

Second, provenance loss occurs when systems paraphrase or synthesize material without traceable sources. Even when the overall meaning is correct, the loss of provenance weakens auditability and undermines the user's ability to evaluate credibility. Documentation proposals such as model cards were developed precisely to counter such opacity by communicating intended use and limitations (Mitchell et al., 2019). In religious knowledge domains, provenance loss is not a minor technical defect; it alters the normative structure of knowledge.

Third, decontextualized one-shot verdicts occur when systems provide ruling-like answers without conditions, interpretive context, or recognition of legitimate disagreement. Such outputs align with known automation bias dynamics, in which users may prefer quick, confident answers and accept them without scrutiny (Parasuraman & Manzey, 2010; Parasuraman & Riley, 1997). They also align with misinformation dynamics, where repetition and confident framing can entrench false beliefs (Lewandowsky et al., 2012; Pennycook & Rand, 2021).

Fourth, ranking and recommendation distortions occur when platform algorithms elevate high-engagement content rather than high-quality content. Studies of social media exposure show that ranking and network structure shape the diversity of information encountered (Bakshy et al., 2015), and research on online news consumption documents filter bubble dynamics shaped by both algorithms and user choice (Flaxman et al., 2016). In religious contexts, such dynamics can elevate polemical or sensational voices, contributing to authority fragmentation and polarized discourse (Bunt, 2018; Larsson & Willander, 2024).

Fifth, bias and stigmatization occur when systems reproduce stereotypes or hostile framings of Islam and Muslims. Bias is not merely an abstract risk: audits of AI systems demonstrate systematic performance disparities across demographic groups (Buolamwini & Gebru, 2018), and critical work shows how search engines and data infrastructures can reinforce oppressive representations (Benjamin, 2019; Noble, 2018). For Muslim minorities, such distortions can contribute to identity harms and reinforce securitized public narratives (Cesari, 2013).

Sixth, privacy risks emerge when users treat conversational systems as confidential counselors and disclose sensitive personal information. Platform governance and content moderation regimes often operate with opaque data retention and policy choices (Gillespie, 2018). In religious counseling contexts, privacy failures can produce both personal harm and broader chilling effects on communal trust.

6 A Maqasid-Informed Governance Framework

6.1 Operational criteria derived from hifz al-din and hifz al-'aql

Interdisciplinary AI governance often struggles to translate value commitments into implementable practices. The maqasid framework is operationalized here by translating hifz al-din and hifz al-'aql into evaluative criteria that can be implemented at the levels of system design, institutional protocol, and user practice (Auda, 2008; Floridi & Cowls, 2018; Morley et al., 2023).

Hifz al-din can be operationalized as (a) attribution integrity (traceable Qur'anic, hadith, and juristic references), (b) interpretive non-usurpation (the system does not present itself as replacing qualified scholarly authority), (c) disciplined representation of plurality (legitimate disagreement is disclosed rather than collapsed), and (d) anti-distortion safeguards (minimizing decontextualization and certainty styling in contested matters).

Hifz al-'aql can be operationalized as (a) uncertainty communication (calibrated confidence and explicit disclosure of limits), (b) contestability and verification affordances (users can inspect sources and challenge outputs), (c) anti-manipulation design (avoiding outrage and polarizing framings), and (d) epistemic literacy support (institutional and community training in verification and critical evaluation). These criteria respond directly to known cognitive and platform mechanisms that facilitate misinformation uptake and overreliance on automation (Lewandowsky et al., 2012; Parasuraman & Manzey, 2010; Pennycook & Rand, 2019).

6.2 Safeguard toolkit across three governance levels

To be practically useful, maqasid-informed criteria must be translated into safeguards that different stakeholders can implement. The toolkit is organized at three levels.

System-level safeguards include provenance-by-design for scriptural content (explicit surah:ayah identifiers for Qur'anic citations and collection-level identifiers for hadith references), refusal and escalation protocols for ruling-like requests, and uncertainty communication when verification is unavailable. Where systems rely on retrieval or ranking, safer retrieval policies and curated corpora can reduce exposure to low-quality or polemical sources. Documentation practices such as model cards can communicate intended use and limitations to institutional adopters (Mitchell et al., 2019). Explainability tools can support auditability in some settings, but governance should also consider whether interpretable models are required for high-stakes uses (Guidotti et al., 2018; Ribeiro et al., 2016; Rudin, 2019).

Institutional safeguards include human-in-the-loop review for high-stakes counseling and public teaching materials, standardized verification protocols for any AI-assisted religious content, accountability documentation for prompts and outputs used in institutional settings, and role-clarity communication that frames AI as augmentation rather than authority. These measures align with broader calls to operationalize AI ethics within organizations and to translate principles into practice (Morley et al., 2023).

User and community safeguards emphasize AI literacy and epistemic hygiene: teaching users to distinguish text from interpretation, to verify citations, to recognize automation bias, and to understand how ranking and recommendation systems shape information exposure (Bakshy et al., 2015; Flaxman et al., 2016; Parasuraman & Riley, 1997). Because misinformation correction is often incomplete, prevention through literacy and verification is essential (Nyhan & Reifler, 2010; Pennycook & Rand, 2021).

Table 1: Epistemic risks of AI-mediated religious guidance and maqasid-informed safeguards

Risk scenario (failure mode)	Epistemic harm	Maqasid objective(s)	Safeguards (system / institution / community)
Fabricated verse/hadith/juristic claim	False attribution; misguidance; erosion of trust	hifz al-din; hifz al-'aql	System: provenance-by-design; refuse unverifiable 'quotes'; uncertainty labeling. Institution: verification protocol before public use; documented sources. Community: verification checklist; source-check norms.
Provenance loss via synthesis/paraphrase	Untraceable claims; flattened disagreement; weak auditability	hifz al-'aql	System: source display; link-out references; disclose disagreement. Institution: require documentation of sources in teaching materials. Community: teach difference between text and interpretation.

Decontextualized one-shot verdict	Misapplication; oversimplified rulings; automation bias	hifz al-din; hifz al-'aql	System: scope control; refusal/escalation for high-stakes queries. Institution: human-in-the-loop review for rulings/counseling. Community: encourage consultation for high-stakes decisions.
Engagement-driven ranking distortion	Unqualified authority amplified; polarization; low-quality content visibility	hifz al-'aql; communal cohesion	System: safer retrieval policies; curated corpora for education. Institution: approved resource lists; institutional curation. Community: media literacy; avoid viral authority cues.
Bias/Islamophobic framing	Stereotypes; identity harm; misinformation normalization	dignity; hifz al-'aql	System: bias audits/red-teaming; harmful framing detection. Institution: public correction protocols; transparent standards. Community: critical consumption training; reporting mechanisms.
Privacy breach in counseling	Exposure/exploitation of sensitive information; chilling effects	privacy/honor; hifz al-'aql	System: data minimization; privacy warnings; avoid storing sensitive chats. Institution: confidentiality policy; approved tools only. Community: do not share sensitive data; awareness education.

7 Illustrative Application: Sunni Muslim Minority Contexts in Western Europe

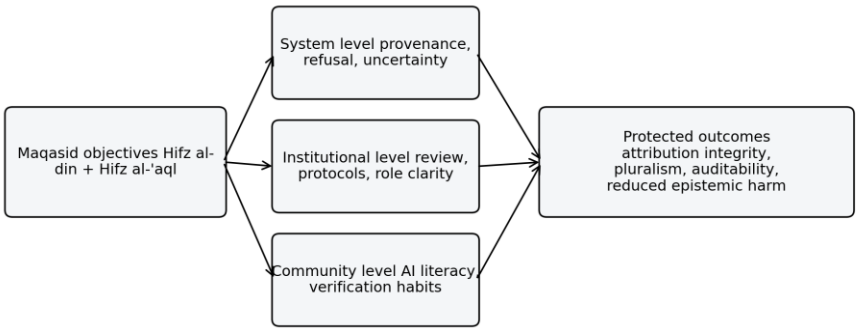


Figure 1: Maqasid-informed governance framework for AI-mediated religious guidance.

This section illustrates how the framework can be applied in Muslim minority settings in Western Europe. The purpose is not to generalize empirically across countries, but to show how contextual conditions can shape exposure to epistemic risks and the feasibility of safeguards.

First, multilingualism and translation needs can increase reliance on automated tools. AI translation and summarization may help users access Arabic lectures or classical texts, but they can also introduce subtle distortions, omit qualifications, or collapse disagreement into a single answer. In diaspora environments where institutional religious education may be limited, such tools can fill an access gap while simultaneously reshaping perceived authority (Bunt, 2018; Larsson, 2011).

Second, fragmented authority and pluralism can heighten the appeal of algorithmic intermediaries. In France, for example, secularist public regimes and contested models of integration shape Muslim institutional life and the public visibility of religion (Bowen, 2010). Across Western Europe, public anxieties about Islam and securitization discourses can create pressures on Muslim communities, affecting trust in institutions and shaping the informational environment in which guidance is sought (Cesari, 2013). In such contexts, AI systems may become attractive because they appear private, immediate, and neutral, even when they are not epistemically reliable.

Third, transnational networks influence the religious knowledge ecosystem. Diasporic communities draw on global flows of scholarship, politics, and media, which reshape what counts as authentic and authoritative. Analyses of transnational Muslim politics highlight how diasporic actors negotiate belonging and authority across borders (Mandaville, 2001), while accounts of globalized Islam describe how deterritorialized religious

discourses circulate through global media and can intensify debates about authenticity (Roy, 2004). When AI systems train on heterogeneous global data, they may reproduce these conflicts without context and present hybridized outputs that erase the boundaries of scholarly schools and interpretive traditions.

Finally, platform ranking and recommendation systems can amplify polemical and sensational content. Online religious learning often occurs through YouTube, TikTok, and other platforms where engagement metrics shape visibility. Studies of online exposure show that algorithmic curation and user choice influence the diversity and quality of information encountered (Bakshy et al., 2015; Flaxman et al., 2016). In Muslim digital spaces, this can elevate charismatic but unqualified voices or polarizing sectarian content, reinforcing the authority fragmentation described in studies of cyber-Islamic environments (Bunt, 2003, 2018). The framework therefore prioritizes curation, verification, and literacy as practical mitigations in diaspora settings.

8 Implications for Stakeholders

8.1 Implications for AI developers and platform designers

For developers and platform designers, the framework implies that religious knowledge domains should be treated as high-trust, high-risk contexts requiring enhanced safeguards. System design should prioritize provenance, calibrated uncertainty, and refusal/escalation mechanisms for high-stakes guidance requests. Documentation regimes such as model cards can communicate intended use and limitations to downstream institutions and reduce misuse (Mitchell et al., 2019).

Bias auditing should be routine, especially for prompts related to Islam, minority identities, and contentious political topics. Research on disparate impact and empirical audits of demographic performance disparities demonstrate why bias cannot be treated as a hypothetical concern (Barocas & Selbst, 2016; Buolamwini & Gebru, 2018). Critical studies of search and data infrastructures further show how representational harms can be amplified through ranking and retrieval (Benjamin, 2019; Noble, 2018).

Explainability tools can support oversight, but they are not a substitute for appropriate model choice and institutional accountability. Surveys of explanation methods show both the breadth of approaches and the open questions about effectiveness and meaning (Guidotti et al., 2018), while local explanation methods aim to increase trust and auditability around particular outputs (Ribeiro et al., 2016). For genuinely high-stakes uses, designers should consider whether interpretable models are necessary to meet accountability requirements (Rudin, 2019).

8.2 Implications for religious institutions and educators

For mosques, community organizations, and Islamic education providers, the framework underscores the need for institutional governance rather than informal adoption. Institutions can harness AI for translation, summarization, and educational scaffolding, but public-facing teaching materials and counseling should follow verification protocols. Human-in-the-loop review is especially critical where outputs resemble fatwa-like guidance or where personal counseling is involved, given the risks of fabrication and overconfidence (Bender et al., 2021; Parasuraman & Manzey, 2010).

Institutions should also explicitly teach epistemic literacy: how to verify citations, how to recognize the limits of AI systems, and how platform ranking shapes information exposure. Because misinformation correction is often incomplete, preventive literacy and verification routines are ethically and practically necessary (Lewandowsky et al., 2012; Nyhan & Reifler, 2010; Pennycook & Rand, 2021).

Finally, institutional leaders should be attentive to how platform moderation and governance decisions shape religious speech and visibility. Platform governance scholarship shows that moderation decisions are not purely technical; they reflect political and commercial choices that structure public discourse (Gillespie, 2018). Religious institutions should therefore develop community guidelines that anticipate platform risks and build resilient knowledge practices.

8.3 Implications for policymakers and civil society

For policymakers and civil society actors, the framework supports a pluralistic approach to AI governance that recognizes cultural and religious specificity without sacrificing universal accountability standards. Global reviews of AI ethics guidelines show convergence on themes such as fairness, transparency, accountability, and human oversight, yet also highlight the gap between high-level principles and implementable regulation (Jobin et al., 2019). Operationalizing these principles requires sector-sensitive toolkits and institutional capacity building (Morley et al., 2023).

In Muslim minority contexts, policy debates are often entangled with securitization and integration discourses. Public fear narratives and political framing can shape what kinds of religious expression are perceived as legitimate, and can influence the informational environment in which AI systems operate (Cesari, 2013; Bowen, 2010). Policymakers should therefore ensure that AI governance and platform regulation do not reproduce discriminatory surveillance or stigmatization, and should support transparency and contestability for AI systems that affect minority communities.

9 Limitations and Future Research Agenda

This article is conceptual and does not present new interview, survey, or ethnographic data. Its Western Europe discussion is illustrative, drawing on established literatures on Muslim minorities, digital religion, and platform dynamics (Bunt, 2003; Bowen, 2010; Cesari, 2013; Larsson & Willander, 2024). Future research should test and refine the framework in specific institutional settings, such as mosques, weekend schools, university Muslim societies, and online fatwa portals.

A practical next step is to conduct systematic prompt audits of generative AI systems for common religious queries. Audit protocols can evaluate fabrication rates for Qur'anic and hadith citations, the clarity of provenance, disclosure of disagreement, and the calibration of uncertainty. Such studies would complement broader misinformation research showing how false content spreads and how corrections can fail (Lazer et al., 2018; Vosoughi et al., 2018), and would connect automation bias theory to real-world religious reasoning practices (Parasuraman & Riley, 1997).

A second priority is institutional case research on governance adoption: how religious institutions actually use AI tools, how verification protocols are implemented, and what organizational barriers emerge. This aligns with research on the difficulties of operationalizing AI ethics within organizations (Morley et al., 2023) and would clarify how documentation tools such as model cards can be adapted for religious knowledge contexts (Mitchell et al., 2019).

A third priority is comparative work on bias and representation. Given documented demographic disparities in AI performance (Buolamwini & Gebru, 2018) and critical analyses of representational harms in search and data infrastructures (Benjamin, 2019; Noble, 2018), future research should examine how Islam and Muslims are represented in AI outputs, retrieval rankings, and platform moderation decisions (Gillespie, 2018).

Finally, interdisciplinary normative research can further explore how tradition-based frameworks contribute to pluralistic AI ethics. Work on Islamic AI ethics benchmarking and trusteeship ethics provides a basis for such engagement (Ali et al., 2025; Elmahjub, 2023), while broader AI ethics guideline synthesis can identify points of convergence and divergence with global frameworks (Floridi & Cowls, 2018; Jobin et al., 2019).

10 Conclusion

Generative AI and recommendation systems are becoming pervasive intermediaries in religious learning and guidance, shaping how users encounter, interpret, and authorize religious knowledge. In Muslim digital contexts, these technologies can expand access to learning and multilingual resources, but they also introduce distinctive epistemic risks: fabricated citation, provenance loss, decontextualized ruling-like outputs, ranking distortions, bias, and privacy harms.

This article proposed a maqasid-informed governance framework that treats AI as epistemic infrastructure rather than a neutral tool. By operationalizing hifz al-din and hifz al-'aql into implementable criteria and safeguards, the framework provides a practical toolkit for developers, institutions, and communities. The paper also positioned Islamic ethical reasoning as a constructive contribution to pluralistic AI ethics, demonstrating how tradition-based values can be translated into concrete socio-technical safeguards.

The core governance lesson is neither rejection nor uncritical adoption. Instead, responsible integration requires provenance and verification protocols, uncertainty and contestability mechanisms, human-in-the-loop oversight for high-stakes guidance, and sustained community literacy about automation bias and platform ranking. With such safeguards, AI can support religious education and access while strengthening, rather than eroding, epistemic security in digital religious life.

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